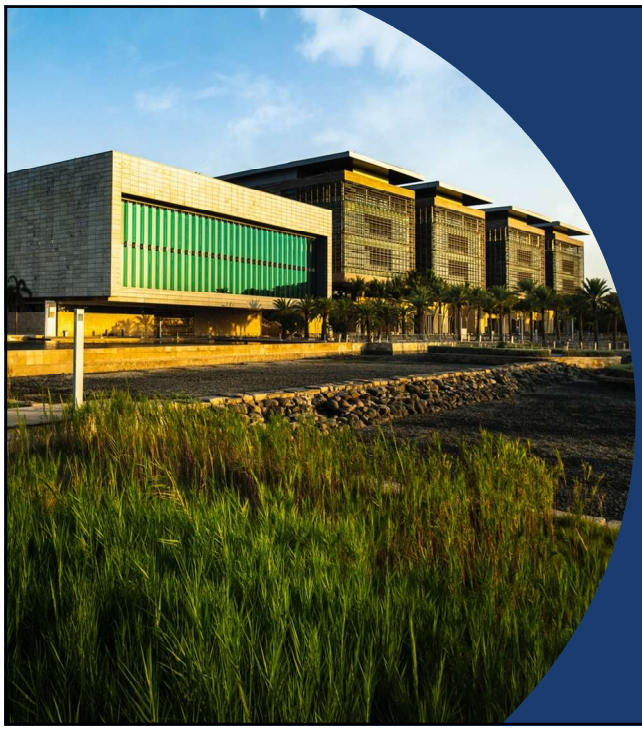

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King Abdullah University of Science and Technology

KSA UNIVERSITIES

DEVELOPING ACADEMIC LEADERS PROGRAM

Leading Strategically

Professor Johnathan Grant,
Dr Tom Kennie, &
Dr Sara Hurley

1

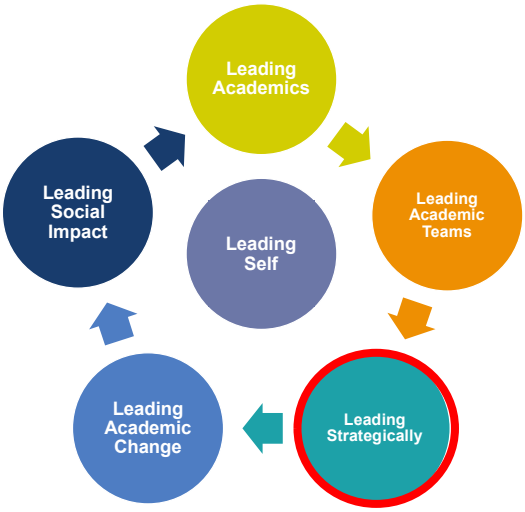
ACADEMIC LEADERSHIP FRAMEWORK

Six Core Capabilities
At the heart of effective deanship:

Leading Self
Understanding your leadership strengths and preferences

Surrounding capabilities:
- *Leading Academics*
- *Leading Academic Teams*
- ***Leading Strategically***
- *Leading Academic Change*
- *Leading Social Impact*

Each capability builds on self-awareness and strengthens your overall leadership effectiveness



2

DAY 3 – WEDNESDAY 1st April- am

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01 Agenda Setting

02 Group Feedback from Visits

03 Leading Strategically

04 Some Conceptual Models

05 BREAK

06 Leading Strategically (cont. + Case Studies

07 Action Learning

3

DAY 3 – WEDNESDAY 1st April- pm

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01 LUNCH AND THE WORK OF THE KAUST ACADEMY

02 Action Learning

03 Leading as 'A First'

04 Walk to Hotels

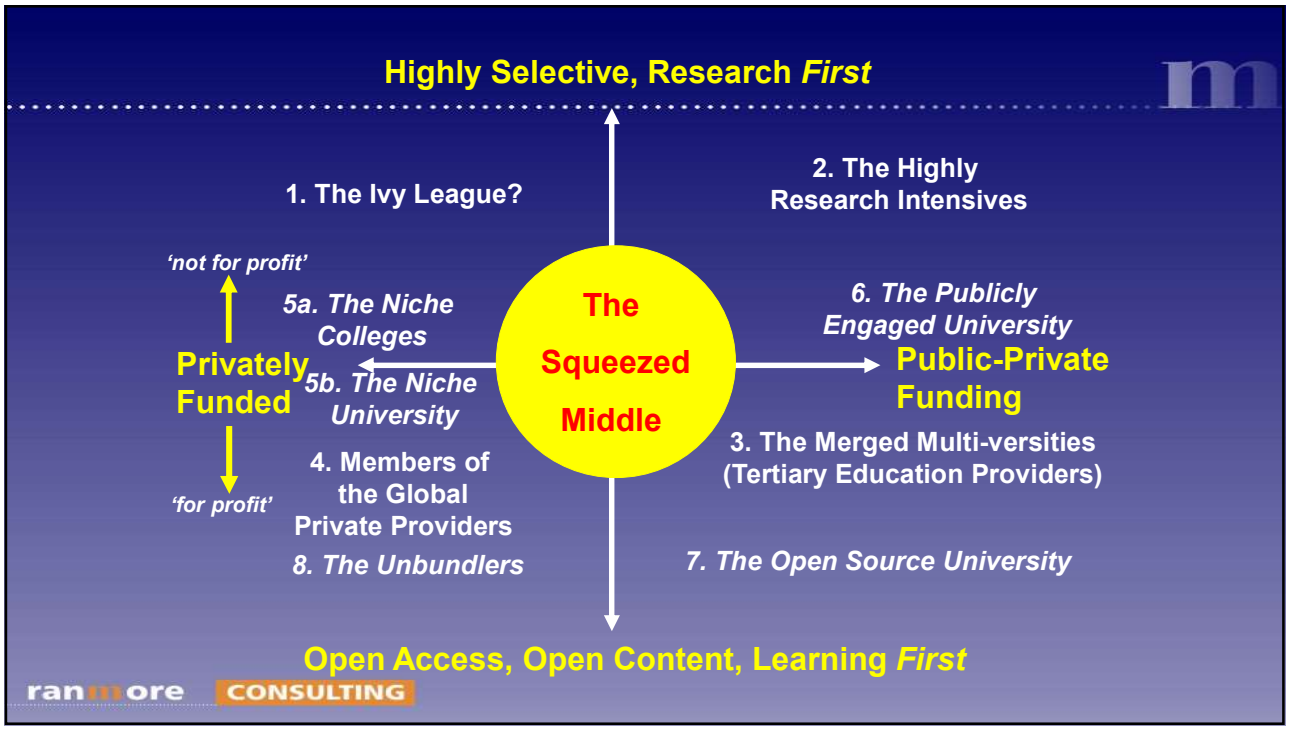
05 Open Evening

4

Reflections and Insights from Visits
Characteristics, Insights & Surprises

- UEL
- QMUL
- Trinity Laban
- ASU
- Meet as sub-groups and create a 3 minute summary of key characteristics, insights and reflections with colleagues

5



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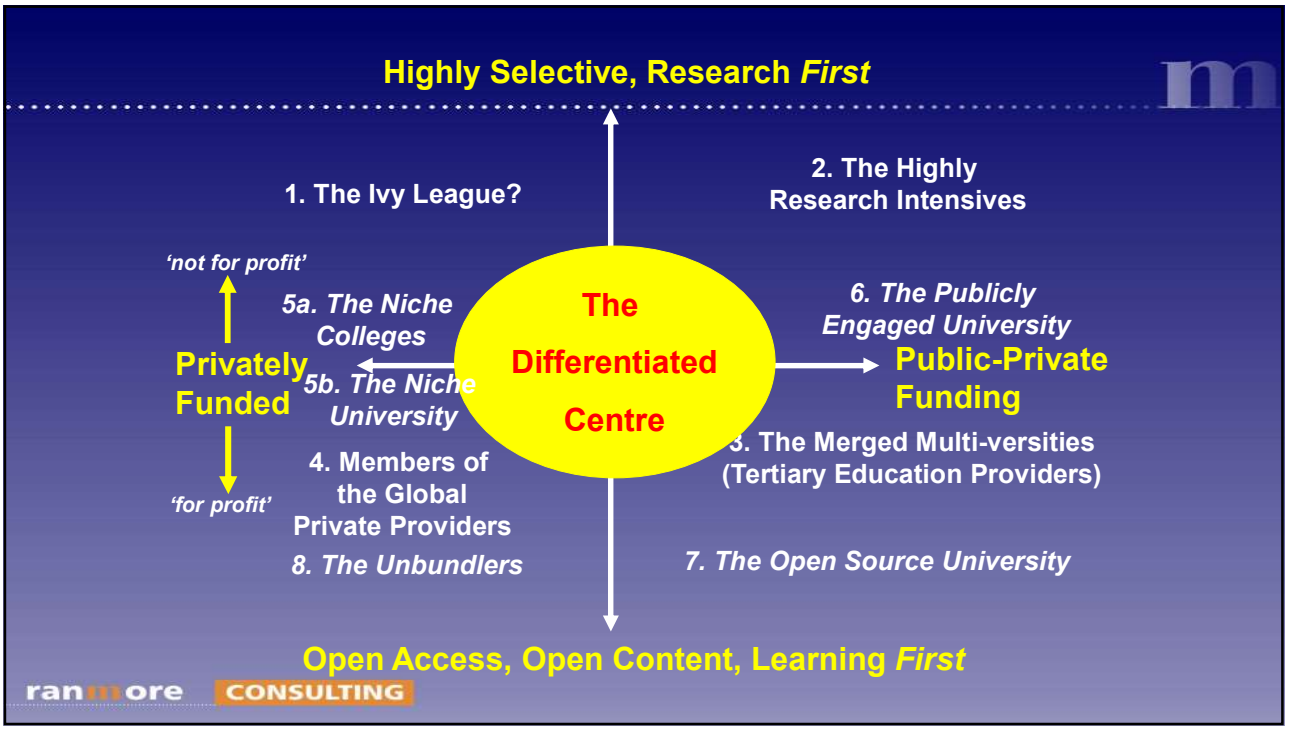
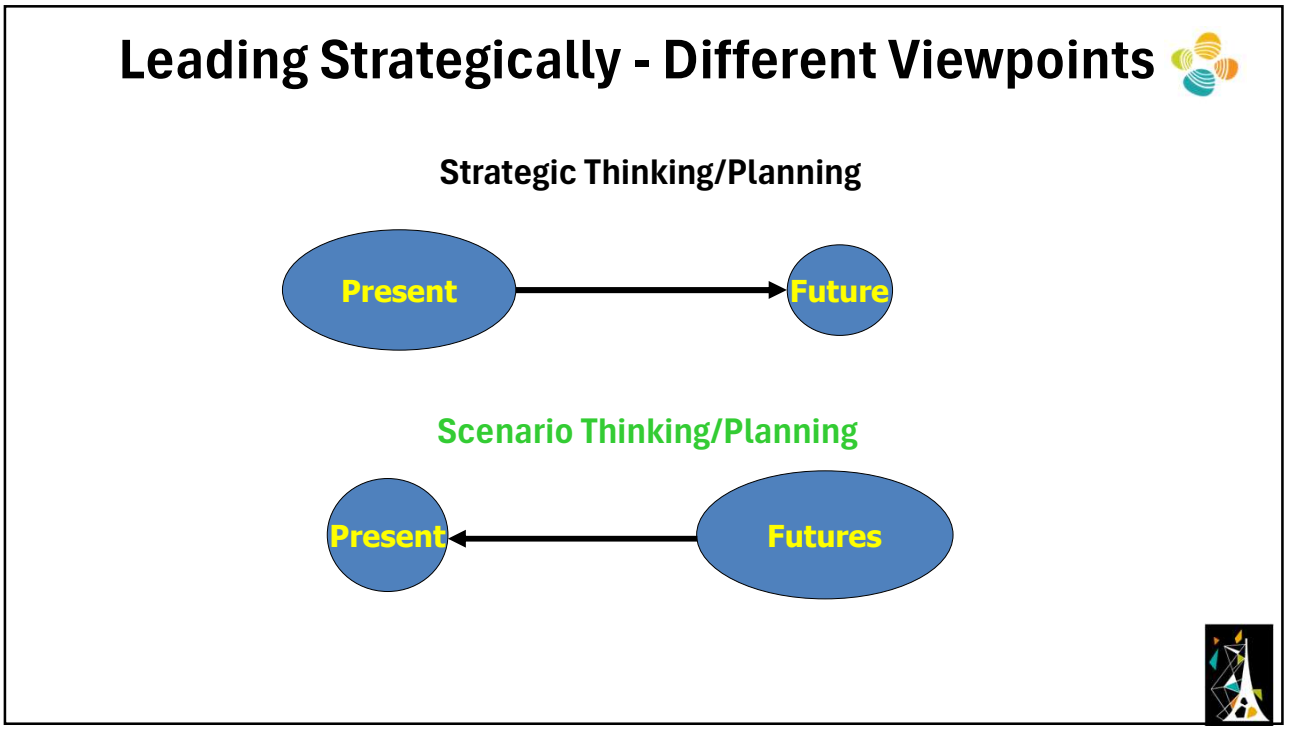
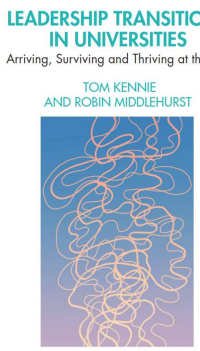

Highly Selective, Research *First*
1. The Ivy League?
2. The Highly Research Intensives
'not for profit'
5a. The Niche Colleges
Privately Funded
5b. The Niche University
'for profit'
The Differentiated Centre
6. The Publicly Engaged University
Public-Private Funding
3. The Merged Multi-versities (Tertiary Education Providers)
4. Members of the Global Private Providers
8. The Unbundlers
7. The Open Source University
Open Access, Open Content, Learning *First*
ranmore CONSULTING

7


Leading Strategically - Different Viewpoints
Strategic Thinking/Planning
Present
Future
Scenario Thinking/Planning
Present
Futures

8



8 Working on the agenda

Do strategy and planning really matter?

If I'm honest with you, I'm a strategy sceptic.

9

The World of Higher Education Podcast **Listen now →**

Higher Education STRATEGY ASSOCIATES

SOLUTIONS INSIGHTS ENGAGEMENT CONTACT EN FR

Strategic Planning for Ambiguous Organizations

November 25, 2019 | Alex Usher

I have been doing a fair bit of strategic planning work recently and one mantra that people like repeating when it comes this kind of exercise is "we're not like a business, so we can't plan like a business". I get why people say this, but they're wrong. Or rather, they're right, but not for the reasons they think.

When people say that "universities aren't businesses", mostly what they are thinking is that universities aren't interested in profit, *per se*. But universities are in most respects actually quite a bit like businesses: they function on rational-bureaucratic lines, they plan their activities to generate sufficient revenue to cover their costs, and in many activities, they plan for surpluses, which are almost indistinguishable from profits. The only reason we don't think of them as being for-profit is that they use those surpluses to cross-subsidize money-losing parts of their operations rather than distributing dividends to owners or shareholders (although, if you stop to think about it, what this means is that effectively the universities' beneficial owners are the people who run the activities which lose the most money).

Now, if the "universities aren't businesses" line was sufficient, then you might think that

One Thought to Start Your Day

One Thought to Start Your Day is our founder and CEO Alex Usher's popular daily blog, brimming with up-to-the-minute insights and informed opinions on today's higher education industry.

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10

Alex Usher[11] is more of a fan of planning and reminds us that

Planning is not the same thing as plans. Planning is the systematic scanning of the horizon for possible change/advantage/disadvantage and discussion/ gaming of options in various circumstances. Plans are specific sequences of tasks meant to get an organization from point A to point B. Dwight Eisenhower is reputed to have said that 'plans are worthless, but planning is everything'. Why? Because reality is brittle. Plans can fall apart in the face of small changes in environment.

11

Usher adds further reflections in *Strategic Planning for Ambiguous Organisations*,[3] in which he postulates two broad types of plans:

- *the laundry-list strategic plan – just a whole bunch of stuff that keeps various constituencies happy. These tend to be heavy on tactics and goals but weak on overarching strategy.*
- *the ultra-vague strategic plan – mission/vision statements which are motherhood statements, and a list of goals that either directly or indirectly are about obtaining more resources for the institution (because the one thing that unites every agenda at a university is the belief that achieving each of them would be a lot easier if there were more dollars available).*

So how do you avoid these issues and get on the right strategic track?

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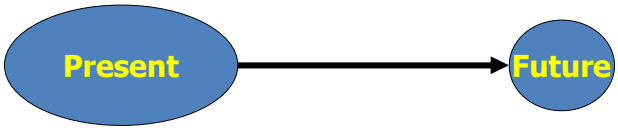
Leading Strategically - Different Viewpoints

Strategic Thinking/Planning



BREAK OUT DISCUSSION

Compare the lived realities of your current strategy or strategic plan

What insights and actions did the completion of the pre-workshop
How Strategic is Your Plan (so far)? questionnaire identify for you?

Any common themes or insights?

13

How Strategic is Your Plan (so far)?

- 1. Strategic Thinking & Horizon Scanning
- 2. Strategic Positioning
- 3. Strategic Context for Change - Readiness
- 4. Strategic Change Management - Implementation
- 5. Strategic Performance Measurement
- 6. Strategic Communication & Engagement
- 7. Strategic Team Working
- 8. Strategic Dis-investment
- 9. Strategic Innovation
- 10. Strategic Emergence & Engagement
- ..... Strategic Learning
- *What 2 actions/lessons did you identify, any patterns?*

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04 Some Conceptual Models

- Strategic Thinking about the Future
- Structured Horizon Scanning & Foresight
- Sense Making and Scenario Thinking

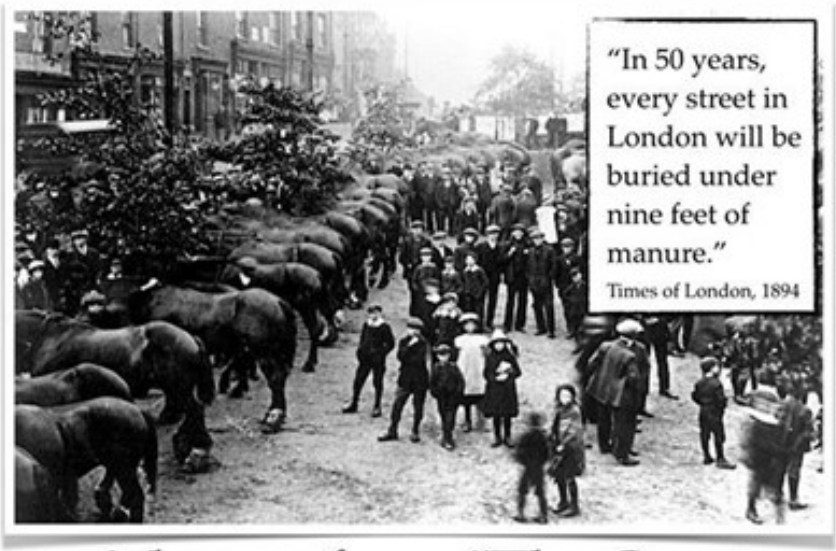
15

What will the world look like in the future?

16

LONDON - 1894

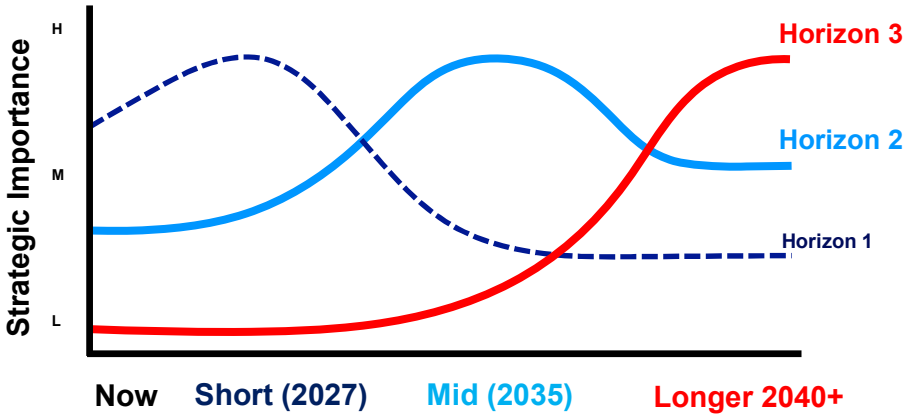
17



A lesson from "The Great Horse Manure Crisis of 1894"

18

Structured Three Level Horizon Scanning



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Strategic Thinking about the Future

What will higher education in KSA look like in 2040?

If you could *speak to someone from 2040* who could tell you *something* about what higher education is like in 2040, *what questions would you like to ask?*

20

Horizon Scanning - PESTEL ANALYSIS

- **P** Political
- **E** Economic
- **S** Social
- **T** Technological
- **E** Environmental
- **L** Legal

21

A Typology of Trends

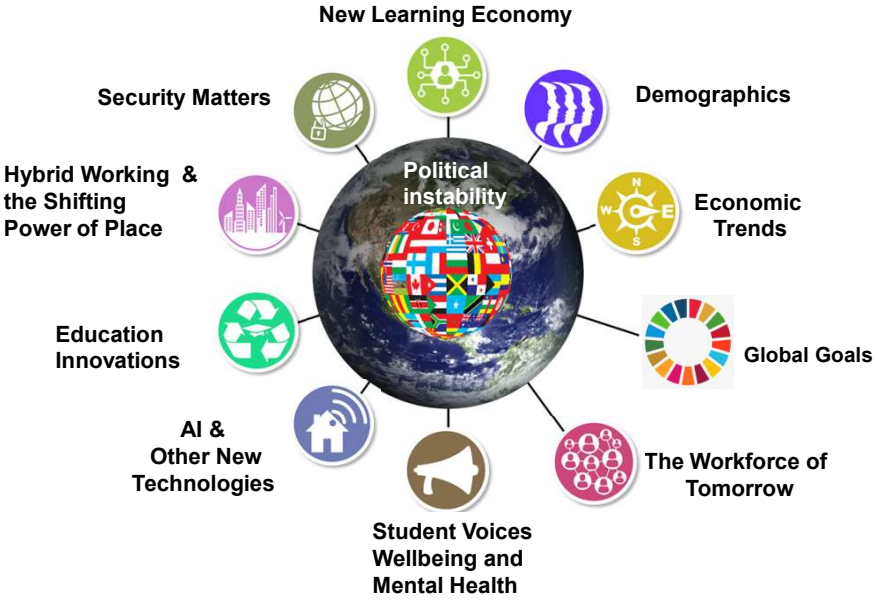
	Demographic trends	The War in Ukraine Iran-US-Israel-Gaza?
Known	*Q1. The 'Known Knowns' Trends we are aware of and need to understand the impact of*	*Q2. Trends we are aware of but don't yet know the full impact of*
Unknown	*Q3. Changes that may catch us out if we don't think about & prepare*	*Q4. Trends we haven't spotted at all and have no real inkling of*
	AI Inflation?	??????
	Known	*Unknown*

The trend is...

The outcome is...

22

Emerging Global and Local Mega-Trends for Higher Education to 2030-40



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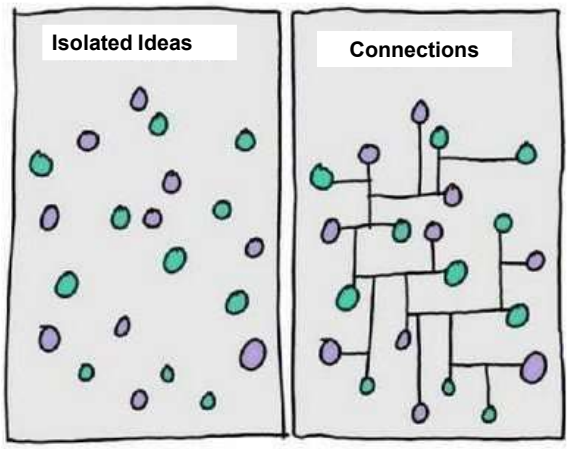
Horizon Scanning
Scan and seek connections



24

More important for the university

The outcome of the trend is certain

The outcome of the trend is uncertain

Less important for the university

25

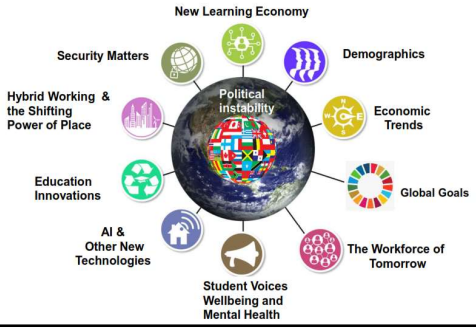
Select a couple of themes/trends from below and drill down to identify an aspect of the trend which is in the top 2 areas

More important for the university

The outcome of the trend is certain

The outcome of the trend is uncertain

Less important for the university



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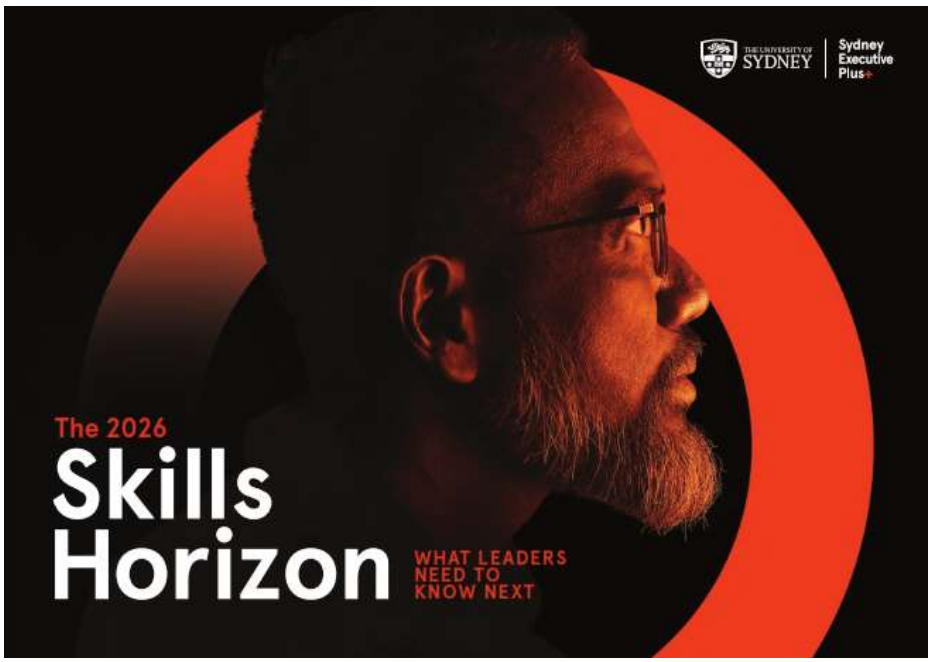
THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY
Sydney Executive Plus+
The 2026
Skills Horizon
WHAT LEADERS NEED TO KNOW NEXT

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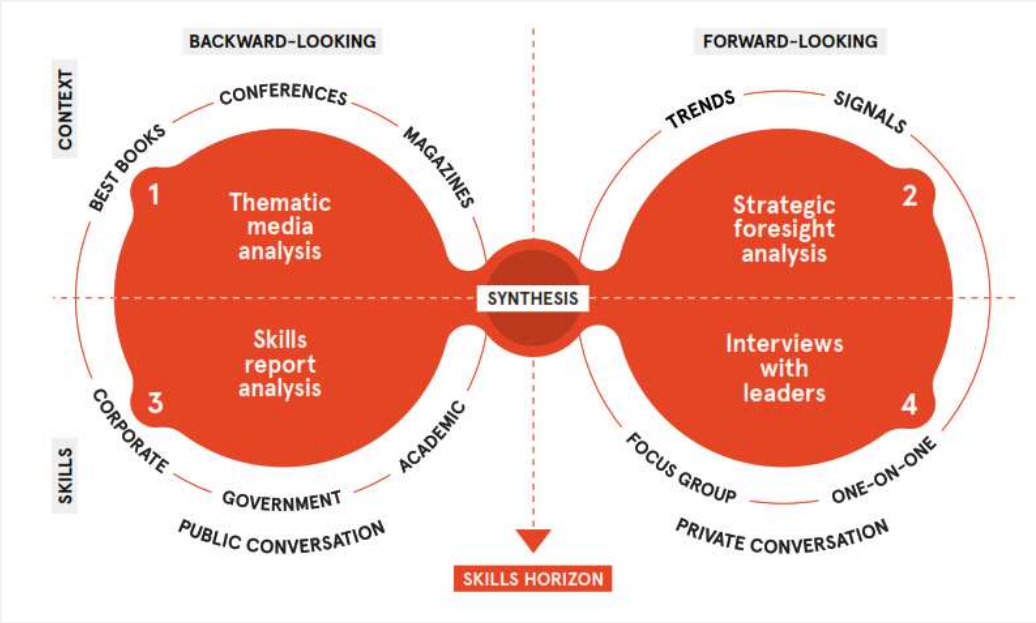
THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY
Sydney Executive Plus+
BACKWARD-LOOKING
FORWARD-LOOKING
CONTEXT
SKILLS
CONFERENCES
BEST BOOKS
MAGAZINES
TRENDS
SIGNALS
1
Thematic media analysis
2
Strategic foresight analysis
SYNTHESIS
3
Skills report analysis
4
Interviews with leaders
CORPORATE
GOVERNMENT
ACADEMIC
FOCUS GROUP
ONE-ON-ONE
PUBLIC CONVERSATION
PRIVATE CONVERSATION
SKILLS HORIZON

28

New Skills for a Messy Future

Skills Based Leader-Development

29

New skills for a messy future

"The truth is no longer the truth. It's much more difficult to agree on facts. Beliefs replace facts and truths, and opinions become the new truth. One of the most difficult challenges for leaders, especially in a global organisation, will be how to manage this when creating a narrative that can bring people together."

Morten Wierod
CEO, ABB

5 things to *worry about*

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

30

New skills for a messy future

5 things to *worry about*

THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY | Sydney Executive Plus+

01 The values shift
Fractured values and fragmenting expectations

Our organisations face unprecedented diversity. Multiple generations, each with different values and work expectations, coexist in our workforce. This internal shift mirrors broader societal changes, demanding that you engage with a wider range of stakeholders both inside and outside your firm.

But we're entering a moment of fragmentation: shifting political norms and changing values bring new fault lines, even in previously unified groups. The attitudes of young men and women are polarising; young men are more conservative than young women. What work means to them, what careers are, what they look for in a leader, how they relate to each other, and what they expect from their organisation and government is changing.

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

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New skills for a messy future

5 things to *worry about*

THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY | Sydney Executive Plus+

02 The technology shift
Strategic necessities with no clear direction

Technology has never been as indeterminate and open-ended as it is now. It's flexible, with seemingly endless opportunities to reshape business, healthcare and society. But technology is also compulsory. Avoidance is not an option. You have to figure it out. What will it mean for your business model? How about your personal productivity? How will it change your customers' habits? How will it be regulated?

Synthetic reality—everything from AI-generated text, voice and video to sales agents, virtual influencers or digital team assistants—will permeate all aspects of our lives. The machine will look like, sound like and behave like us. Synthetic possibilities will challenge our business models as much as they'll challenge our education systems and our democracies.

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

32

New skills for a messy future

5 things to *worry about*

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03 The accountability shift
Accountability across boundaries and the provenance economy

We need to rethink accountability. Sustainability, decarbonisation, regulation and the new geopolitics require a shift of perspective from the organisation to the systems level. And as the world reaches the limits of its social and environmental ecologies, provenance, tracking and tracing become crucial.

> "With the increase in new regulatory obligations in markets like the European Union, organisations have to shift from 'story telling' to 'story proving'. To 'prove' their products and services, they have to collaborate with others, both upstream and downstream from them, in order to collect evidence and trusted data to maintain compliance and access to those markets."
>
> **Laszlo Peter**
> CEO, KPMG Origins

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

33

New skills for a messy future

5 things to *worry about*

THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY | Sydney Executive Plus+

04 The trust shift
The erosion of trust in institutions, ideas and geopolitical stabilities

The foundations of trust are shifting. New instabilities have brought into focus its normally invisible foundations: taken for granted principles, institutions, relationships and norms.

In the year when more democracies voted than at any time in human history, trust in traditional institutions and enduring ideas like liberal democracy are in sharp decline. And there are more eyes than ever on the role of businesses, their legitimacy and their social licence to operate important services and systems in and for society. Taking on these responsibilities requires trust, which has to be earned continuously, and at scale.

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

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New skills for a messy future

5 things to *worry about*

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05 The energy shift
An inelegant transition without a coherent story

The energy transition from fossil fuels to renewables is slower, more fragmented, more complex than anticipated. The pace of progress has slowed due to economic volatility, increased geopolitical confrontations, technological shifts and the hottest years on record several times over.

We could further lose momentum. As the adoption of artificial intelligence ramps up, the demand for generative searches and generative content could skyrocket, and with it the demand for electricity to power data centres.

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

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New skills for a messy future

5 things to *worry about*

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01 The values shift
Fractured values and fragmenting expectations

02 The technology shift
Strategic necessities with no clear direction

03 The accountability shift
Accountability across boundaries and the provenance economy

04 The trust shift
The erosion of trust in institutions, ideas and geopolitical stabilities

05 The energy shift
An inelegant transition without a coherent story

How relevant are these shifts to higher education? If so, how do they translate?

Source: The 2025 Skills Horizon (Peter et al 2024)

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The Curious Leader

It's The Curious Leader who'll be best equipped to make sense of the mess and lead through it.

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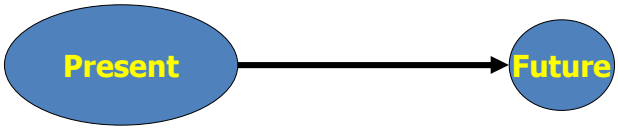
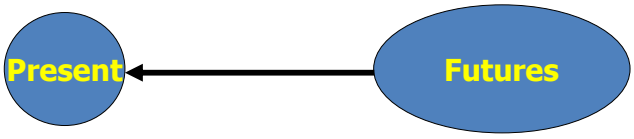
Leading Strategically - Different Viewpoints

Strategic Thinking/Planning



Scenario Thinking/Planning



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Scenario Thinking

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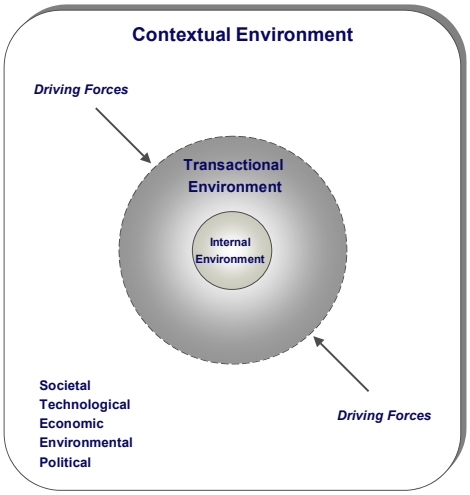
Scenario Thinking
Exploring Alternative Futures

1. Identify what is driving change
2. Decide which change drivers are critical and uncertain
3. Construct the scenario matrix
4. Develop the scenarios
5. Review your current vision and strategic priorities



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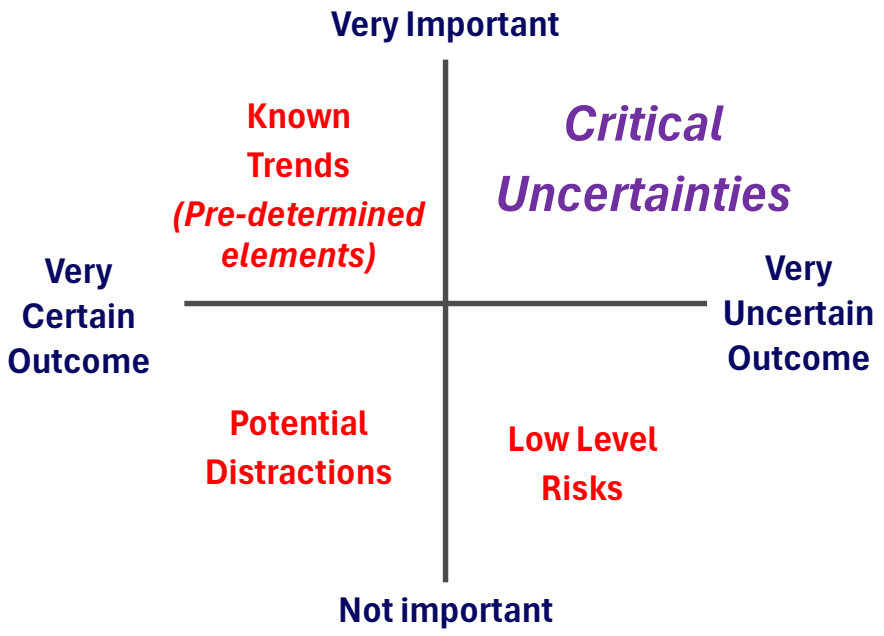

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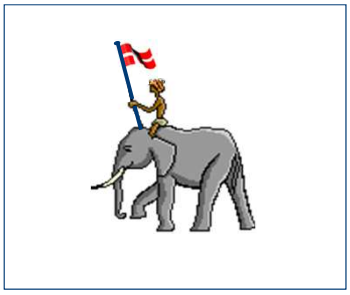
THINK OF A NUMBER…

BETWEEN 2 AND 9
MULTIPLY BY 9
ADD THE INTEGERS TOGETHER
SUBTRACT 5
TRANSFER TO A LETTER (1=A, 2=B ETC.)
THINK OF A COUNTRY BEGINNING WITH THE LETTER
TAKE SECOND LETTER OF THAT COUNTRY
THINK OF AN ANIMAL
WHAT COLOUR IS THE ANIMAL?

42

Think of a number…



Predetermined element: **The sum of the two numbers is 9**

Critical uncertainties: **Can you do the arithmetic? ,**

Do you have the cultural context to select Denmark?,

Can I communicate properly?

43

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Table 1: The Four Scenarios

		Funding environment	
		Constrained	Benign
Government approach	*Laissez-faire*	Scenario 1 **Retrenchment** **The evolution of the present**	Scenario 2 **Expansion** **Delivering the 2010 vision**
	Interventionist	Scenario 4 **Segmented** **A differentiated system**	Scenario 3 **Tertiary** **A place-based tertiary system**

45

Radically Re-Thinking the University of 2040

Higher Education Futures Paper:
The End of the Old U? Radically Re-Thinking the University

elementa leadership

March 2026

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The University of the Future: Four Bold Archtypes

The paper proposes four institutional archetypes as possible futures—not predictions.

- **The Global Frontier:** a high-trust steward of frontier capability and standards.
- **The Civic Enterprise:** a placed-based anchor institution for skills, inclusion, and innovation.
- **The Boundaryless Platform:** flexible learning at scale through immersive digital delivery, portable credentials, and robust trust architecture.
- **The Mission Specialist:** purpose-built around a defined societal or sector mission, proving capability through practice and deep partnership.

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The Global Frontier

The Global Frontier – At A Glance	
Strategic role	High-trust flagship for frontier knowledge, advanced skills, and standards that "stand up" under scrutiny
Authorising logic	Capability + credibility
What society gets	High-cost research platforms; trusted stewardship of evidence; long-horizon inquiry + demonstrable impact
Learner proposition	Research-led education at scale; formation of judgement for complex, high-stakes contexts
Knowledge & research	Broad base, but selective frontier platforms; strategic collaboration; governed openness (security + values-based partnerships)
Business model	Capital-intensive; diversified funding (public investment, major grants, philanthropy, international, partnerships, exec/PG premium)
Governance & leadership	Stewards of independence + credibility; strong "trust architecture" (integrity, provenance, ethics, reproducibility)
Failure modes	Elitism/legitimacy backlash; integrity shocks; capture/mission drift; cost/complexity creep
Sub-types	Frontier kitemarks; comprehensive global flagships; premium residential variants

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The Civic Enterprise

The Civic Enterprise – At A Glance	
Strategic role	Place-anchored civic and economic platform: indispensable to region, open to all, delivering visible contribution over prestige
Authorising logic	Usefulness that can be seen
What society gets	Regional productivity + inclusive growth; stronger public services; social cohesion; convening power across employers, public bodies, education, health, culture, and communities
Learner proposition	Flexible, supported participation; clear progression across HE/FE; strong links to local opportunity and professions
Knowledge & research	Applied, regionally relevant translation and evaluation; mobilises partners to move from evidence to implementation
Business model	Demand-led + employer-funded learning; applied partnerships / public service contracts; shared regional infrastructure
Governance & leadership	Outward-facing, coalition-building, politically literate; legitimacy and narrative treated as strategic capabilities; CEO not CAO
Failure modes	Gap-filler; loss of focus; over-promising civic contribution without the resources to sustain it; short-term metrics; political capture
Sub-types	Public service anchors; innovation hubs; tertiary system integrators

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The Boundaryless Platform

The Boundaryless Platform – At A Glance	
Strategic role	Lifelong, on-demand learning at scale through immersive digital participation
Authorising logic	Access + adaptability at scale
What society gets	Expanded participation beyond geography/life stage; rapid re-skilling; truly portable credentials that travel across boundaries
Learner proposition	Membership-style "learning home": enter/exit/re-enter over time; stack credentials; belonging and support without co-location
Knowledge & assessment	Credibility through trust architecture: authentic performance with engineered identity/provenance and auditable evidence trails
Business model	Campus-light or no physical estate by design; investment in immersive environments, student success, and assurance; scale is essential
Governance & leadership	CEO-style platform leadership; boards treat integrity, identity, data governance, and cyber resilience as existential
Failure modes	High-tech but thin (weak belonging/care); integrity/data shocks; digital divide; scale vs human depth
Sub-types	Fully immersive virtual universities; hub-and-immersion networks; global credential/capability platforms

50

The Mission Specialist

The Mission Specialist – At A Glance	
Strategic role	Purpose-built specialist with radical focus on a defined societal/sector mission
Authorising logic	Targeted capability
What society gets	Hard-to-substitute capability for priority missions—often where regulation, ethics, and trust matter; clear routes into fields with demonstrable outcomes
Learner proposition	Mission-led pathways with practitioners; authentic assessment (observed practice, simulations, in-context problem-solving); employability + purpose
Knowledge & research	Applied, translational, deeply partnered; moves from evidence to implementation through mission consortia
Business model	Mission-aligned revenue: employer/professional education, applied partnerships, public commissioning, philanthropy, joint-ventures; often campus-light and partner-site based
Governance & leadership	Disciplined mission focus; manages deep partnerships without losing autonomy; invests in transparent standards and external validation
Failure modes	Over-dependence on one partner distorts mission; mission drift; "training not education"; speed vs integrity
Sub-types	Public service specialists; sector co-owned universities; private mission institutions

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2040 – What do you think is the most likely balance for your university across these four archetypes? *(distribute 100%)*

The Global Frontier	The Boundaryless Platform
The Civic Enterprise	The Mission Specialist

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DAY 3 – WEDNESDAY 1st April- am

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King Abdullah University of Science and Technology

01 Agenda Setting

02 Group Feedback from Visits

03 Leading Strategically

04 Some Conceptual Models

05 BREAK

06 Leading Strategically - Case Studies (JG/SH

07 Action Learning

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Action Learning

THEORY

- ***'Action learning is a continuous process of learning and reflection that happens with the support of a group of colleagues, working on real issues with the intention of getting things done.*** **(McGill and Brockbank, 2004)**

PRACTICE

- ***'A well established leadership development peer coaching process aimed at helping you and your colleagues address real life challenges and opportunities in a safe space'***

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GROUND RULES

CONFIDENTIALITY

- All members (including the facilitators) will consider the content of discussions, which take place within the action learning group as confidential. This will also extend to discussions involving any third parties mentioned during the meetings.
- No disclosure of the identify of individuals or orgnisations mentioned during the Action Learning Groups will be made to other Groups or other parties (unless express permission has been given).

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GROUND RULES

- Members will seek to be sensitive to others' approaches to problem solving and seek to assist the individual to resolve the dilemma/deal with their issue, rather than advise on a solution (unless invited to do so by the person outlining the issue under discussion);
- When presenting, members will respect the right of the person outlining the issue to limit their level of disclosure;
- Participants will actively contribute to the meetings and will allow each person in the group to contribute;
- The overall tone of each meeting/discussions should aim to be open and supportive.

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Process

- **Each person has an equal time slot**
- **Typically, we start by you setting the context for the specific issue you have chosen as the particular matter on which you are seeking assistance (5 – 7 mins)**
- **All in the group are then invited to ask a question which is designed to help the person address or explore the issue from a different perspective**

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Next Steps

- Move into small groups
- Invite each person to provide an introduction to the
  - Context, organisation, role,
  - Challenges and opportunities
- Use this to Choose a Selected issue to share as each person's action learning project.

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